

Testicles

Testicles are part of the male reproductive system. Each testicle is a factory producing sperm, the male sex cells. Testosterone, the hormone that controls the development of male puberty, is also made in the testicles.

How they work

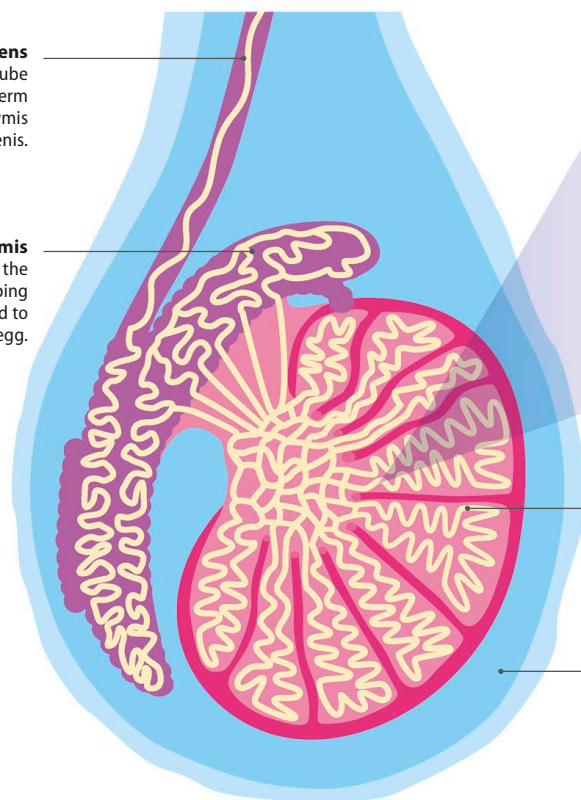
Two testicles are housed in a protective pouch of skin called the scrotum. The scrotum helps keep the temperature of the testicles slightly cooler than the body's core temperature of 99°F (37°C). The testicles hang outside the body, because they produce sperm best at about 95°F (35°C). To stop them bumping into each other, it's common for one testicle to hang lower than the other. It's also perfectly normal for them not to be symmetrical.

▽ Inside the testicle

The average testicle is small, oval-shaped, and about 2 in (5 cm) in length from end to end. After puberty starts, each testicle continues making around 3,000 sperm per second, until the end of a man's life.

Vas deferens
This is a long, wide tube through which sperm travels from the epididymis to the penis.

Epididymis
Sperm mature in the epididymis by developing the ability to move and to fertilize an egg.



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◀ 48–49 Male hormones

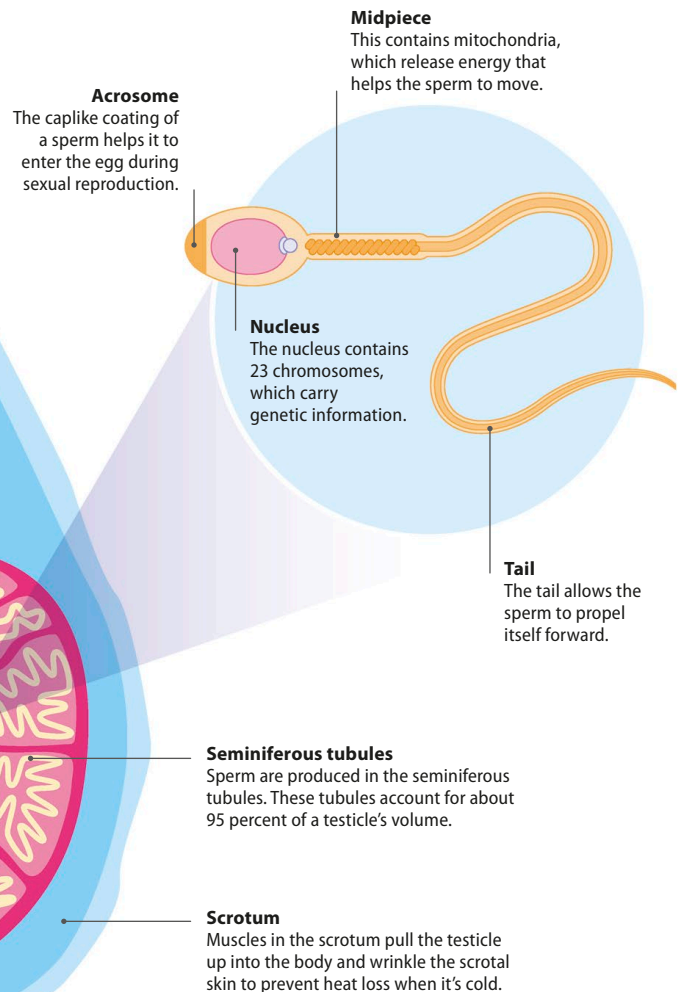
◀ 50–51 Changing body

The penis

54–55 ▶

▽ Sperm

Each sperm contains genetic information from the male, and its function is to move toward and fuse with an egg, the female sex cell, during sexual reproduction. Sperm live only for a few days.



Seminiferous tubules
Sperm are produced in the seminiferous tubules. These tubules account for about 95 percent of a testicle's volume.

Scrotum
Muscles in the scrotum pull the testicle up into the body and wrinkle the scrotal skin to prevent heat loss when it's cold.